

PROTOCOL DICE ENGINE

CORE RULEBOOK

v0.005 PRE-ALPHA

A classless roleplaying engine with modern-occult magic built
into its core.

Contents

- Core Rules — core roll, difficulty, Ability dice, Skills, and ranks
- Characters — creation, Talents, equipment, action rules, combat, and recovery
- Magic — Practices, casting modes, implements, consequences, countermagic, and Workings
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- Quick Reference — essential procedures at the table

Welcome to Protocol Dice

Protocol Dice is a classless roleplaying engine for contemporary occult stories, investigations, action, horror, science fiction, and other campaigns. Characters are defined by Abilities, learned Skills, individually selected Talents, equipment, relationships, and—when the campaign allows it—magical Practices.

This is a PRE-ALPHA foundation release. Its purpose is to put the complete play loop, classless character structure, Talent language, and first playable magic system in one place for testing.

The Core Roll

Roll only when the outcome is uncertain, consequential, and failure would change the situation. Define what the character is trying to accomplish, choose the Skill that covers that scope, assemble the complete pool, and roll once. Results of 1, 2, or 3 are blank. Every result of 4 or higher scores its face value. Add all scoring faces and compare the total with a Difficulty Class or an opposing total.

Standard pool: three associated Ability dice + one Skill die. This is the ordinary four-die baseline.

Edge Die: add the single strongest relevant die supplied by gear, a Talent, assistance, preparation, advantage, or circumstance. Ordinary Edge Dice do not stack. A rule that truly adds a sixth die says so explicitly.

Multiple edges still matter. Lesser edges may provide permission, remove a disadvantage, improve effect, protect against a consequence, reduce time, or broaden what success accomplishes.

Difficulty and Margin

DC	Difficulty
8	Easy under pressure
12	Moderate
16	Hard
20	Very hard
24+	Extreme

Winning margin	Result
1-3	Narrow
4-7	Solid
8-11	Powerful

Winning margin	Result
12+	Overwhelming

Failure creates the next problem; it should not erase the only path forward. A tie on an opposed roll favors the defender or existing situation. On an Overwhelming success, grant one directly related benefit: greater effect, reduced time, improved position, useful information, protection from a consequence, or an allied opportunity.

Advantage, Disadvantage, and Help

Minor, clear, and major advantages normally offer d4, d6, and d8 Edge Dice. Because only one ordinary Edge Die enters the pool, use the largest relevant die.

Disadvantage removes a die: d4 for minor, d6 for clear, or d8 for major. If that exact die is absent, remove the next-highest die present; if none is higher, remove the highest available. Never reduce a pool below one die. Multiple disadvantages may apply when they arise from genuinely separate problems.

Assist normally costs 1 AP in action time. A helper must describe a useful contribution and possess relevant access. Assistance normally supplies a d4 Edge Die, or a larger die when a Talent explicitly permits it.

Abilities

Ability	Meaning
STR	Strength
DEX	Dexterity
CON	Constitution
INT	Intellect
WIS	Wisdom
CHA	Charisma

Repeated Ability dice are intentional. A Skill may use the same Ability twice when that trait dominates the task. Assign d8, d8, d6, d6, d4, and d4 among the six Abilities.

Skills and Ranks

A Skill defines learned expertise and names the three Ability dice used with it. Rank 0 is untrained d4. Ranks between breakpoints are Progress Ranks: they count toward advancement but do not change the die until the next breakpoint.

Rank	Skill die
0	d4
1	d6
3	d8
6	d10
10	d12
15	d12+d4
21	d12+d6
28	d12+d8
36	d12+d10

Rank	Skill die
45	d12+d12

General Skills — 1 of 2

Skill	Ability dice	Uses
Athletics	STR / STR / CON	Climbing, swimming, lifting, endurance
Acrobatics	DEX / DEX / STR	Balance, tumbling, agile movement
Stealth	DEX / DEX / WIS	Hiding, shadowing, quiet movement
Perception	WIS / WIS / INT	Notice details, detect danger, surveillance
Investigation	INT / INT / WIS	Research, evidence, deduction
Survival	WIS / CON / INT	Navigation, tracking, fieldcraft
Medicine	INT / WIS / DEX	Treatment and stabilization
Science	INT / INT / WIS	Experimentation and analysis
Engineering	INT / INT / DEX	Repair, design, improvisation
Computing	INT / INT / WIS	Software, electronics, data
Security	DEX / INT / WIS	Locks, alarms, bypasses

General Skills — 2 of 2

Skill	Ability dice	Uses
Tradecraft	WIS / INT / CHA	Covert work and surveillance
History	INT / INT / WIS	Records, context, institutions
Culture	INT / WIS / CHA	Etiquette, communities, customs
Linguistics	INT / INT / CHA	Languages, codes, translation
Influence	CHA / CHA / WIS	Persuasion and negotiation
Deception	CHA / CHA / INT	Lies, disguise, misdirection

Skill	Ability dice	Uses
Leadership	CHA / WIS / CON	Command and coordination
Driving	DEX / WIS / INT	Ground vehicles
Piloting	DEX / INT / WIS	Aircraft and unusual vehicles
Initiative	DEX / DEX / WIS	Act quickly when conflict begins

Combat Skills — 1 of 2

Skill	Ability dice	Uses
Unarmed	STR / DEX / CON	Strikes and close control
Light Melee	DEX / DEX / STR	Knives, batons, compact weapons
Heavy Melee	STR / STR / CON	Axes, clubs, heavy weapons
Sidearms	DEX / DEX / WIS	Pistols and similar weapons
Longarms	DEX / WIS / CON	Rifles and carbines
Shotguns	DEX / CON / WIS	Close-range shoulder weapons
Automatic Weapons	DEX / CON / STR	Automatic fire and suppression

Combat Skills — 2 of 2

Skill	Ability dice	Uses
Precision Weapons	DEX / DEX / WIS	Long-range deliberate fire
Heavy Weapons	STR / DEX / CON	Launchers and crew-served weapons
Thrown Weapons	DEX / STR / WIS	Thrown weapons and charges
Improvised Weapons	STR / DEX / INT	Ordinary objects used as weapons
Grappling	STR / STR / CON	Grab, hold, restrain, shove
Disarming	DEX / STR / INT	Remove or redirect held objects
Tactics	INT / WIS / CHA	Positioning and coordination

Defense Skills

Skill	Ability dice	Uses
Dodge	DEX / DEX / WIS	Avoid aimed attacks
Reflex	DEX / WIS / CON	Explosions, traps, sudden areas
Fortitude	CON / CON / STR	Toxins, exhaustion, bodily shock
Will	WIS / WIS / CHA	Fear, coercion, supernatural pressure
Recovery	CON / WIS / CON	Stabilizing and recovery

Magic Skills — 1 of 2

Skill	Ability dice	Uses
Evocation	WIS / CHA / CON	Project force, energy, motion, or elements
Enchantment	CHA / WIS / INT	Influence emotion, attention, and intention
Illusion	INT / CHA / WIS	Alter perception and apparent reality
Restoration	WIS / INT / CON	Repair living patterns and purge afflictions
Divination	WIS / INT / CHA	Reveal hidden patterns, traces, and possibilities
Warding	INT / WIS / CON	Create boundaries, protections, and seals

Magic Skills — 2 of 2

Skill	Ability dice	Uses
Transformation	CON / INT / WIS	Alter bodies, substances, and forms

Skill	Ability dice	Uses
Summoning	CHA / INT / WIS	Call, negotiate with, and bind entities
Spirit	WIS / CHA / CON	Perceive and interact with spirits and echoes
Alchemy	INT / WIS / DEX	Prepare magical compounds and reactions
Artifice	INT / DEX / WIS	Create and repair enchanted objects
Necromancy	WIS / INT / CON	Work with death, remains, and lingering identity

Creating a Character

1. Describe the person before assigning numbers: identity, background, present trouble, strongest relationship, and reason to act.
2. Assign the Ability array d8, d8, d6, d6, d4, d4.
3. Spend 20 starting Skill Ranks. No Skill may begin above rank 6 unless the campaign changes the limit.
4. Record 18 maximum HP, 3 AP, and one normal Reaction.
5. Choose three starting Talents. A campaign may grant an additional origin Talent shared by everyone.
6. Choose ordinary equipment appropriate to the campaign.
7. If magic is permitted, establish how the character gained access and purchase magical Practices like other Skills. Choose magical Talents among the same three starting Talents.
8. Record bonds, obligations, beliefs, resources, and complications that the GM can bring into play.

Suggested Disciplines may recommend Skills and Talents, but they are never classes, restrictions, or automatic packages.

Talents

Talents are trained capabilities, signature techniques, unusual gifts, specialized methods, or supernatural abilities. Abilities describe natural capability. Skills describe learned competence. Talents describe distinctive permissions, methods, and exceptions. Equipment describes available tools.

Talents are normally standalone. Permitted requirements are a minimum Skill rank, a broad experience tier, or a fictional qualification. Named-Talent prerequisites should be rare and limited to a direct improvement of the same technique.

A Talent may supply the fifth Edge Die when no ordinary tool captures the advantage—especially Initiative, awareness, composure, social instinct, unarmed training, and magic. Most Talents instead grant an action, Reaction, permission, margin option, substitution, preparation, or controlled consequence.

Universal Talent rules

- A Talent does only what its Effect states. Flavor does not create additional permission.
- A Talent must be declared when its Trigger says; it cannot be declared retroactively after later information is known.
- Costs are paid when declared and are not refunded because the roll fails or the situation later changes.
- Ordinary Edge Dice do not stack. The same Talent cannot affect the same roll more than once.
- The same event cannot trigger the same Talent repeatedly.
- A Reaction Talent obeys the one-Reaction limit and Reaction AP rules unless it explicitly overrides them.
- A granted attack is still an attack. Granted movement is not a Move action unless stated.

- Once per scene resets only when location, objective, and opposition have materially changed—not merely when initiative stops.
- A Talent cannot manufacture missing access, tools, knowledge, targets, perception, consent, or physical possibility unless its Effect explicitly supplies it.
- Specific Talent text overrides a general rule only for the named situation. Resolve remaining ambiguity with the narrowest reading that preserves the evident function.

Awareness Talents

Danger Sense

Type: Passive

Requirement: You must be conscious and capable of perceiving the surrounding area.

Trigger: You assemble a pool to detect an immediate ambush, trap, or physical threat, before rolling.

Cost: None.

Effect: Add a d6 Edge Die when detecting an immediate ambush, trap, or physical threat.

Edge Die: Provides a d6 Edge Die; use only the largest applicable Edge Die.

Duration: That detection roll.

Frequency: Once for each distinct threat the GM permits a roll to detect.

Limits: Applies to immediate danger, not general Investigation, motives, remote surveillance, or threats already fully known.

Example: Danger Sense adds d6 when you have a chance to notice a concealed attacker about to strike.

Not permitted: It does not reveal the identity, exact location, plan, or statistics of a threat without a successful roll and supporting fiction.

Combat Talents

Counterattack

Type: Reaction

Requirement: You must be able to make a legal close attack against the attacker.

Trigger: After you win a close defense and before the attacker's action is fully resolved.

Cost: Your Reaction and 4 points of winning margin from that defense.

Effect: After winning a close defense, spend your Reaction and 4 margin to make an immediate basic attack against the attacker.

Edge Die: The granted attack uses its normal pool and at most one ordinary Edge Die.

Duration: Immediate.

Frequency: Once per available Reaction and no more than once per triggering attack.

Limits: Spending margin cannot reduce the defense below a win. The counterattack is a normal attack and can be defended against.

Example: You win a knife defense by 7, spend 4 margin, and immediately make one Unarmed attack.

Not permitted: It does not make the counterattack automatic, free from defense, or capable of triggering itself.

Driving Blow

Type: Attack modifier

Requirement: A legal close attack.

Trigger: Declare before assembling or rolling the attack pool.

Cost: You cannot use a Reaction until the beginning of your next turn.

Effect: Before a close attack, give up your Reaction until your next turn. On a hit, spend margin to force movement, break protection, or knock the target down.

Edge Die: None unless another valid source provides the attack's one Edge Die.

Duration: Through the attack; the Reaction restriction lasts until your next turn.

Frequency: Once per close attack, but its Reaction cost cannot be paid again while already unavailable.

Limits: On a hit, spend winning margin on damage or stated physical effects; the same margin cannot be spent twice. The GM sets costs based on scale.

Example: You give up your Reaction, hit by 6, deal 2 damage and spend 4 margin to knock the target down.

Not permitted: It cannot create extra margin, affect an impossible target, or preserve a Reaction through another rule unless that rule explicitly overrides this cost.

Unarmed Specialist

Type: Passive

Requirement: Training appropriate to the character's unarmed method.

Trigger: You assemble an Unarmed attack or defense pool where physical technique is relevant.

Cost: None.

Effect: Your trained body counts as appropriate d6 equipment for unarmed attacks and defenses where physical technique matters.

Edge Die: Your trained body counts as d6 equipment and can provide the one Edge Die.

Duration: That roll.

Frequency: Whenever the trigger applies.

Limits: Does not stack with another Edge Die and does not make your body a tool for unrelated Skills.

Example: While disarmed, you still add d6 as the Edge Die to an Unarmed strike.

Not permitted: It does not make unarmed attacks silent, ranged, harmless, concealable from witnesses, or automatically legal in the fiction.

Defense Talents

Bodyguard

Type: Reaction

Requirement: You must perceive the attack, be adjacent to the ally, and be a legal target.

Trigger: An adjacent ally is selected as the target of an attack, before the attack pool is rolled.

Cost: Your Reaction; pay any AP required by the normal Reaction rules.

Effect: When an adjacent ally is attacked, use your Reaction to become the target and move the ally behind you before defense is rolled.

Edge Die: None.

Duration: Immediate.

Frequency: Once per available Reaction.

Limits: Move the ally no more than 5 feet to the nearest legal position beside or behind you. Cannot affect area effects, attacks already rolled, or effects that cannot target you.

Example: A gunman targets the investigator beside you; you exchange positions and defend against the shot.

Not permitted: It cannot teleport you, protect several allies from one explosion, or redirect an attack after its result is known.

Mobile Guard

Type: Action modifier

Requirement: You take the Guard action and can legally move.

Trigger: When resolving Guard.

Cost: The normal Guard cost; no additional AP for the granted movement.

Effect: After taking the Guard action, you may move up to 10 feet as part of the same action without abandoning the guard.

Edge Die: None.

Duration: Movement is immediate; Guard lasts normally.

Frequency: Once per Guard action.

Limits: Move up to 10 feet and maintain the stated protection. Terrain and movement restrictions still apply. This is not a Move action for effects that require one.

Example: You Guard a doorway and shift 10 feet to keep yourself between an ally and the entrance.

Not permitted: It cannot cross impassable terrain, disengage automatically, trigger free movement repeatedly, or expand Guard beyond its declared subject or area.

Investigation Talents

Investigator's Eye

Type: Passive information permission

Requirement: You must personally examine the scene or evidence for a meaningful interval.

Trigger: You begin a focused examination.

Cost: The time and access required by the examination; 1 AP if used as Observe during action time.

Effect: When examining a scene, the GM always reveals one concrete detail genuinely out of place. The roll determines context, clarity, and cost.

Edge Die: None.

Duration: The examination.

Frequency: Once per materially distinct scene or newly introduced body of evidence.

Limits: The GM reveals one concrete detail genuinely out of place. A roll determines context, clarity, additional facts, and cost. The detail need not be the solution.

Example: At a staged burglary, the GM reveals that one broken window scattered glass in the wrong direction.

Not permitted: It cannot demand the culprit's identity, solve a mystery automatically, or repeatedly mine the same unchanged scene for new anomalies.

Leadership Talents

Coordinated Action

Type: Assist modifier

Requirement: You can communicate or coordinate and possess a relevant Skill.

Trigger: You take the Assist action and identify your useful contribution.

Cost: Normal Assist cost, usually 1 AP.

Effect: When you Assist, the recipient may use your relevant Skill die as the Edge Die, to a maximum of d8.

Edge Die: The recipient may use a die equal to your relevant Skill die, to a maximum of d8, as the roll's one Edge Die.

Duration: The assisted roll defined when Assist is declared.

Frequency: Once per Assist action.

Limits: Multiple helpers do not add multiple Edge Dice. Your contribution must be possible and relevant. Multi-die Skill ratings use the largest single Skill die, capped at d8.

Example: Your Tactics d10 supplies a d8 Edge Die to an ally's next coordinated attack.

Not permitted: It cannot Assist actions you cannot perceive or influence, supply a sixth die, or remain available for an entire scene.

Magic Talents

Ritualist

Type: Permission

Requirement: At least rank 1 in the Practice used and fictional access to ritual instruction.

Trigger: You design or join ritual magic.

Cost: Time, tools, participants, links, and risks established before the roll.

Effect: You may perform ritual magic, gathering time, tools, participants, and symbolic links to extend scale, duration, or reach.

Edge Die: Ritual tools or preparation may provide the one Edge Die; Ritualist itself provides none.

Duration: The ritual and the resulting effect's stated duration.

Frequency: Whenever sufficient time and requirements are available.

Limits: Extending scale, duration, reach, or precision requires concrete preparation. One roll resolves the ritual unless distinct stages have separate stakes.

Example: You use a name, chalk circle, two assistants, and an hour to ward an apartment for a week.

Not permitted: It cannot replace missing sympathetic links, eliminate consequences, make every effect permanent, or stack unlimited preparation dice.

Battle Casting

Type: Passive

Requirement: Ability to perform immediate magic.

Trigger: You cast immediate magic while threatened, distracted, or under close physical pressure.

Cost: None.

Effect: You may perform immediate magic while threatened without the usual clear disadvantage for distraction or close pressure.

Edge Die: None.

Duration: That casting attempt.

Frequency: Whenever the trigger applies.

Limits: Removes only the usual clear disadvantage caused by close pressure or distraction. Other disadvantages remain, including restraint, blindness, injury, silence when required, or hostile countermeasures.

Example: A hostile creature is within reach, but you cast without losing a die solely for that pressure.

Not permitted: It does not prevent attacks, remove all disadvantages, grant an Edge Die, or allow casting when the method is physically impossible.

Implement Bond

Type: Selection and passive

Requirement: Magical access and a personal implement chosen when the Talent is acquired.

Trigger: You cast with the bonded implement in hand or otherwise used as its established method.

Cost: Possession and use of the implement.

Effect: Choose a personal magical implement. When it is appropriate and in hand, it provides a d6 Edge Die to one chosen Practice.

Edge Die: Provides a d6 Edge Die to one Practice chosen when this Talent is acquired.

Duration: That casting roll.

Frequency: Whenever the trigger applies.

Limits: The Practice and implement are fixed until a major story transition permits replacement. It does not stack with another Edge Die.

Example: Your engraved ring provides d6 to Warding when you trace a boundary with it.

Not permitted: It cannot apply to every Practice, function while unavailable or broken, or supply a sixth die.

Implementless Casting

Type: Passive permission

Requirement: Magical access.

Trigger: You attempt immediate magic without an implement.

Cost: None.

Effect: You can attempt immediate magic without an implement. Lack of an implement does not impose disadvantage, though an implement may still provide an Edge Die.

Edge Die: Provides no Edge Die; another valid source may provide the one Edge Die.

Duration: That casting attempt.

Frequency: Whenever the trigger applies.

Limits: Removes only the normal disadvantage or prohibition for lacking an implement. Other required speech, movement, links, materials, or access remain if the working needs them.

Example: After losing your wand, you can still attempt an immediate Veil without a missing-implement penalty.

Not permitted: It does not make casting silent, invisible, impossible to interrupt, or free of all components and fictional requirements.

Countermagic

Type: Reaction

Requirement: You perceive the effect in time, can affect it, and possess a relevant magical Practice.

Trigger: A magical effect is being created, sustained, or entering an area you can influence, before its consequences are finalized.

Cost: Your Reaction and any AP required by normal Reaction rules.

Effect: Use your Reaction to oppose a magical effect you can perceive with the most relevant Practice. On a win, reduce or redirect it as the fiction permits.

Edge Die: Use the normal Practice pool and at most one valid Edge Die.

Duration: Immediate; a reduced or delayed result lasts as adjudicated from the margin.

Frequency: Once per available Reaction and once per triggering effect.

Limits: State whether you aim to cancel, reduce, redirect, delay, or expose the effect before rolling. The GM confirms which outcomes are possible.

Example: You oppose an incoming curse with Warding, seeking to delay it until the end of the round.

Not permitted: It cannot counter imperceptible completed effects retroactively, guarantee cancellation, or redirect an effect to an illegal target.

Trace Reader

Type: Passive sensory permission

Requirement: Magical access and proximity to a lingering trace or a method that can reach it.

Trigger: You deliberately examine possible magical residue.

Cost: Time to examine; normally 1 AP as Observe during action time.

Effect: You can perceive lingering magical traces. Divination or Spirit determines age, direction, emotional tone, and recognizable signature.

Edge Die: None.

Duration: The examination.

Frequency: Once per distinct trace or after the trace materially changes.

Limits: You can perceive that a trace exists. Divination or Spirit determines age, direction, tone, Practice, and signature. Old, veiled, contaminated, or unfamiliar traces may be incomplete.

Example: You detect residue on a doorway, then roll Divination to learn that it is a recent Warding effect.

Not permitted: It does not identify every caster automatically, reveal the full working, track indefinitely, or bypass deliberate concealment without a roll.

Veiled Working

Type: Casting modifier

Requirement: Magical access and a working whose signs can plausibly be reduced.

Trigger: Declare before casting.

Cost: The working may trade speed, force, or convenience for concealment as established before rolling.

Effect: When casting, you may reduce visible and sensory signs. This cannot hide consequences that are themselves obvious.

Edge Die: None.

Duration: For the working's casting and sensory signs.

Frequency: Once per casting attempt.

Limits: Reduces visible and sensory signs of the process. It cannot hide an obvious result, collateral effect, injury, transformed object, or witness knowledge.

Example: You cast a subtle ward through a phone gesture, but the door still visibly refuses to open when triggered.

Not permitted: It does not make magic undetectable, erase traces automatically, conceal consequences, or grant silent casting when speech is indispensable.

Warden

Type: Ritual modifier

Requirement: Ritualist and at least rank 1 in Warding.

Trigger: You design a ward and define its recognition rules before rolling.

Cost: The normal ritual requirements plus keys, names, samples, tokens, or definitions needed for recognition.

Effect: Your wards can recognize named people, creatures, conditions, or tokens and respond differently to each.

Edge Die: None by itself.

Duration: The ward's duration.

Frequency: Once per ward design.

Limits: The ward may recognize specifically named people, categories, conditions, or tokens supported by the preparation. Ambiguous definitions produce ambiguous behavior.

Example: A ward admits anyone carrying one of three marked brass keys and warns you when a key is copied.

Not permitted: It cannot be omniscient, understand undefined intent, identify unknown categories without criteria, or rewrite its conditions after creation.

Binder

Type: Ritual permission

Requirement: Ritualist, magical access, and willing participants capable of meaningful agreement.

Trigger: All participants knowingly enter a stated supernatural bargain.

Cost: Ritual time, agreed terms, and a declared consequence or enforcement mechanism.

Effect: You may create enforceable supernatural bargains with willing participants. Ambiguous language creates equally ambiguous enforcement.

Edge Die: None by itself; appropriate symbols or leverage may provide the one Edge Die if a roll is required.

Duration: Until the stated fulfillment, breach, release, or expiration.

Frequency: One binding per completed bargain.

Limits: Terms must be stated and understood. Ambiguity is enforced ambiguously. The Talent does not create consent, authority, or impossible enforcement.

Example: Two rivals swear not to enter a named building for thirty days, with a visible mark appearing on breach.

Not permitted: It cannot bind an unwilling or incapable target, hide material terms from a participant, or grant unlimited punishment unrelated to the agreement.

Familiar Bond

Type: Persistent relationship

Requirement: Magical access and a fictional event establishing the bond.

Trigger: Chosen when the Talent is acquired; the familiar acts when present and able.

Cost: The familiar has a need, obligation, vulnerability, or reciprocal expectation defined with the GM.

Effect: You have a bonded minor entity with an identity, need, and limited form. It can observe, communicate, and Assist within its nature.

Edge Die: When it meaningfully Assists, it normally provides a d4 Edge Die unless its profile states otherwise.

Duration: Persistent until ended through play.

Frequency: The familiar acts according to normal scene timing and cannot Assist the same roll more than once.

Limits: Define its minor form, senses, communication, movement, and one narrow capability. It is an NPC with motives, not remote equipment.

Example: A crow familiar scouts an open courtyard and reports what it sees, but cannot read sealed files inside.

Not permitted: It cannot possess unlimited range, perfect knowledge, invulnerability, unrestricted actions, or abilities not established in its profile.

Alchemy Workshop

Type: Passive facility benefit

Requirement: A stocked, accessible workshop established in the fiction.

Trigger: You create an Alchemy preparation primarily within that workshop.

Cost: Normal preparation time and consumed materials.

Effect: With a stocked workspace, Alchemy preparations gain a d8 Edge Die instead of the normal d6 for professional tools.

Edge Die: The workshop provides a d8 Edge Die instead of the normal d6 for professional tools.

Duration: That preparation roll.

Frequency: Whenever the workshop is available and adequately stocked.

Limits: Does not stack with another Edge Die, travel with the character, replace rare ingredients, or apply after the workshop is compromised.

Example: You brew a Prepared Draught in your laboratory and use the workshop's d8 as the fifth die.

Not permitted: It cannot grant d8 in the field, create ingredients, speed every preparation automatically, or supply a sixth die.

Signature Working

Type: Limited reroll

Requirement: Know one narrowly defined Working chosen when the Talent is acquired.

Trigger: After rolling that Working but before the total is compared or consequences are resolved.

Cost: Use this Talent's once-per-scene use and accept the new Skill-die result.

Effect: Choose one narrowly defined Working. Once per scene, reroll its Skill die, keeping the new result.

Edge Die: None; this rerolls only the Skill die and does not add dice.

Duration: Immediate.

Frequency: Once per scene.

Limits: Reroll every die that constitutes the Skill die if the rating uses two dice; keep the complete new Skill result. The chosen Working is fixed until a major story transition.

Example: After rolling your Signature Veil, you reroll its d8 Skill die and must keep the replacement.

Not permitted: It cannot reroll Ability or Edge Dice, wait until consequences are announced, keep the better result, or apply to an improvised effect merely similar to the named Working.

Medicine Talents

Field Medic

Type: Action permission

Requirement: Access to the patient and a plausible method of treatment.

Trigger: You attempt to stabilize a dying adjacent living character.

Cost: 2 AP in action time.

Effect: Stabilize an adjacent dying character for 2 AP without rolling when immediate danger does not interfere. Under pressure, Medicine determines additional treatment.

Edge Die: None by itself; appropriate medical gear may provide the one Edge Die when a roll is required.

Duration: Immediate stabilization; additional treatment follows the Medicine result.

Frequency: Once per treatment attempt; repeat attempts require a changed approach or situation.

Limits: No roll is required only when immediate danger does not interfere. Under pressure, roll Medicine. It does not restore HP unless another rule says so.

Example: Behind secure cover, you stabilize an ally for 2 AP; under fire, you roll Medicine instead.

Not permitted: It cannot stabilize at range, treat the dead, ignore inaccessible injuries, or repeatedly roll without a changed circumstance.

Mobility Talents

Quick to Act

Type: Passive

Requirement: None.

Trigger: You assemble an Initiative pool, before rolling.

Cost: None.

Effect: Add a d6 Edge Die to Initiative. This does not stack with another Edge Die; use the largest.

Edge Die: Provides a d6 Edge Die to Initiative; use it only if it is the largest applicable Edge Die.

Duration: That Initiative roll.

Frequency: Every time Initiative is rolled.

Limits: Does not add a sixth die, stack with gear or another Edge Die, or apply to later actions in the conflict.

Example: You have no useful gear for reacting to an ambush, so Quick to Act supplies the fifth die.

Not permitted: It does not grant an extra turn, AP, Reaction, or automatic first place.

Social Talents

Silver Tongue

Type: Passive

Requirement: The target can understand and engage with your apparently friendly conversation.

Trigger: You assemble a pool to distract through friendly conversation, before rolling.

Cost: None beyond maintaining the conversation.

Effect: Add a d6 Edge Die when distracting someone through apparently friendly conversation.

Edge Die: Provides a d6 Edge Die; use only the largest applicable Edge Die.

Duration: That distraction attempt.

Frequency: Once per distinct conversational approach; repeated attempts require new leverage or changed circumstances.

Limits: Applies to distraction, not every Influence or Deception roll. Cannot override language barriers, hostility that prevents conversation, or impossible requests.

Example: You keep a receptionist talking while an ally slips through a staff door.

Not permitted: It does not charm, control, erase suspicion, or make the target ignore obvious danger.

Technology Talents

Jury-Rig

Type: Action or extended task

Requirement: Access to the device, plausible tools or materials, and enough understanding to attempt the repair.

Trigger: You attempt to make a damaged or incomplete device function temporarily.

Cost: At least 1 AP in action time; complex work requires more time as set before rolling.

Effect: Make a damaged or incomplete device function for one scene. Engineering determines reliability, limitations, and danger.

Edge Die: Appropriate tools may provide the one Edge Die.

Duration: Normally one scene or until the stated failure condition occurs.

Frequency: One attempt per device until the approach, materials, or damage meaningfully changes.

Limits: Engineering determines function, reliability, limits, and danger. The repair cannot exceed what the available parts could plausibly do.

Example: You bypass a burned controller so an elevator works for one trip, knowing it will fail afterward.

Not permitted: It cannot create missing fuel, knowledge, software, rare components, or permanent repairs from nothing.

Equipment and the Edge Die

One primary relevant item may provide the Edge Die. Compatible items do not stack unless a rule explicitly says otherwise. A tool normally ranges from d4 for a useful ordinary item, to d6 for professional equipment, d8 for exceptional or specialized equipment, and d10+ only for extraordinary campaign-defining devices.

Weapons use their listed gear die as the Edge Die on attacks. Armor uses its die on a defense when it can physically protect the wearer; armor does not also subtract damage unless a specific rule says it does. Implements use the same rule for magic.

Action Time

Action	Cost and effect
Attack	1 AP; make one normal attack
Move	1 AP; move up to 30 feet; repeatable
Interact	1 AP
Take Cover	1 AP
Aim	1 AP; d4 Edge Die on the next deliberate ranged attack before the end of your next turn
Assist	1 AP
Guard	1 AP; establish the stated protective response
Observe	1 AP
Stand	1 AP
Withdraw	1 AP; disengage safely where possible
Stabilize	2 AP
Grapple	2 AP
Disarm	2 AP

A character receives 3 AP on a turn. Unspent AP remains available during the Reaction window. A Reaction spends banked AP first. If none remains, the character may borrow 1 AP from the next turn; that turn begins with one fewer AP. Unused banked AP expires when the next turn begins.

Combat

Roll Initiative when order matters. Each participant uses the Initiative Skill and any applicable Edge Die.

An attack is an opposed complete pool. The defender chooses the defense that matches the threat: Dodge for aimed attacks, Reflex for sudden areas and traps, Fortitude for bodily assault, Will for fear and coercion, or another defense established by the fiction. Ties favor the defender. On a hit, damage normally equals the attacker's winning margin.

At 0 HP, a character is dying or otherwise unable to continue. At the start of each turn, roll Fortitude against DC 12. Three Recoveries stabilize the character; three Dangers mean death or another campaign-appropriate terminal outcome. A Solid success counts as two Recoveries and a Powerful or Overwhelming success counts as three. Harm already taken remains when maximum HP changes.

Conditions, Hazards, and Recovery

A condition should say what is true, what it prevents, and how it ends. Use disadvantage only when the condition directly hinders the attempted action. Examples include Restrained, Blinded, Frightened, Burning, Exhausted, and Exposed.

Hazards use DCs when passive or complete pools when actively opposed. Consequences may deal margin damage, impose a condition, consume time or equipment, separate the group, worsen position, or reveal a new threat.

After a safe full rest, recover all HP unless the campaign uses slower recovery. Medicine and Restoration can address immediate danger, but serious injuries may remain as fictional conditions after HP returns.

Magic in Protocol Dice

Magic is part of the core engine but not mandatory in every campaign. Its default presentation is contemporary occult fantasy: secret communities, inherited gifts, private mentors, formal academies, personalized implements, supernatural bargains, hidden laws, modern institutions, and dangerous beings living beside ordinary life. The rules do not require a particular world, century, religion, or universal magical authority.

Magic is not a class. Access must be established in the fiction, then expressed through magical Practice Skills, Talents, Workings, implements, relationships, and obligations. There are no spell levels, spell slots, prepared-spell lists, or required arcane/divine division.

Casting Magic

State the intended effect, target, range, duration, and visible method. The GM confirms the closest Practice and whether the effect is Immediate, Ritual, or Downtime magic. Build the normal pool: the Practice's three Ability dice, its Skill die, and at most one Edge Die. Compare against a DC or an opposing pool.

Immediate magic acts within a scene and is limited enough to resolve as an action. A typical working costs 1 AP; a broad attack, sustained control, summoning, or complex alteration may cost 2 AP.

Ritual magic uses time, preparation, symbols, links, participants, and controlled space to extend scale, duration, distance, or precision. Ritualist is required unless the working explicitly allows ritual use by anyone with the Practice.

Downtime magic creates preparations, enchanted objects, long investigations, or durable changes between active scenes.

A caster may **overreach** by expanding one axis beyond the safe scope: scale, range, duration, targets, speed, or precision. The caster accepts a meaningful magical consequence even on success. Expanding more than one axis normally requires a ritual, extraordinary leverage, or both.

Implements, Links, and Traces

An implement is a personal or purpose-built focus: wand, staff, ring, marked coin, knife, book, instrument, electronic device, tattoo, prayer cord, or another object consistent with the practitioner. An appropriate implement normally supplies a d4 or d6 Edge Die; a bonded or exceptional implement may supply d8.

A sympathetic link connects a working to its subject: a true name, blood, handwriting, treasured object, photograph, location, repeated

habit, or direct magical trace. Links grant permission for effects that cannot reasonably find a distant or hidden subject on their own.

Magic leaves traces when the effect, failure, or consequence makes that meaningful. Traces may reveal Practice, emotional tone, direction, age, participants, or an individual signature. Veiled Working can reduce signs but cannot erase obvious results.

Magical Consequences

Choose consequences from the fiction rather than a universal mana tax. Common consequences include backlash, fatigue or injury, unwanted attention, a distorted effect, a broken implement, a supernatural obligation, a lingering trace, collateral harm, loss of control, or something answering the working.

Consequences should create decisions. They should not routinely make magic useless or punish a player merely for choosing a magical character. A failed roll can still produce the intended effect at a serious cost when that keeps the story moving.

Countermagic, Wards, and Entities

A character with Countermagic may use a Reaction to oppose a perceptible magical effect using the most relevant Practice. Winning can cancel, reduce, redirect, delay, or expose the effect as established before rolling. Existing wards may defend without an active caster.

Wards must define a boundary, protected subject, trigger, and response. A ward cannot intelligently distinguish everything unless a Talent, named key, or carefully written condition provides that capability.

Summoned entities are characters, not equipment. They have motives, limits, and ways of interpreting commands. A binding establishes permitted and forbidden behavior; it does not erase

identity. True consent, leverage, names, hospitality, debts, and local supernatural law can matter more than raw force.

Practices and Workings

Practices describe how a character approaches magic. Workings are tested applications that establish expected scope; they are not the only possible effects. Creative casting is encouraged, but a broad Practice is not permission to solve every problem without limits. The GM compares a new effect with existing Workings, establishes its mode and stakes, and calls for one roll when consequences matter.

Alchemy Workings

Prepared Draught (Downtime)

Store one narrow magical effect in a consumable preparation with a declared trigger and shelf life.

Artifice Workings

Circle Key (Downtime)

Create a token that opens, closes, or identifies a specific ward or ritual boundary.

Divination Workings

Read the Residue (Immediate)

Learn what kind of magic occurred here and follow a sufficiently fresh trace.

Possible Path (Ritual)

Ask what is likely if a stated course is followed. The answer is a conditional possibility, never certainty.

Enchantment Workings

Quiet Thought (Immediate)

Dampen one immediate emotion or impulse. It cannot rewrite identity or manufacture loyal devotion.

Compelling Word (Immediate)

Press a simple immediate suggestion. Obvious self-destruction or violated core loyalties grant major resistance.

Evocation Workings

Kinetic Shove (Immediate)

Push, pull, or knock down a visible target. Winning margin determines force and distance.

Kindle (Immediate)

Create or intensify a small flame; attacking with it is opposed normally.

Illusion Workings

Veil (Immediate or Ritual)

Conceal a person, object, or area from ordinary perception. Interaction and scrutiny can oppose it.

Borrowed Face (Ritual)

Adopt the appearance and voice of a studied person; behavior and knowledge are not supplied.

Necromancy Workings

Question the Dead (Ritual)

Question a lingering identity through remains or a strong link. Death does not guarantee honesty or complete memory.

Still the Corpse (Immediate)

Prevent remains from being animated, possessed, altered, or used as a sympathetic link for the scene.

Restoration Workings

Mend Flesh (Immediate)

Stabilize and restore HP equal to winning margin, once per injury until proper recovery.

Purge (Ritual)

Oppose a poison, disease, curse, or invasive magical influence.

Spirit Workings

Speak with Echo (Ritual)

Communicate with an emotional or spiritual impression attached to a person, object, or place.

Ghost Light (Immediate)

Reveal nearby spirits, echoes, and active supernatural presences as visible signs.

Summoning Workings

Call Minor Entity (Ritual)

Invite or compel a minor entity whose name, nature, location, or symbolic link is known.

Dismiss (Immediate)

Drive a summoned or displaced entity from the current scene; its rightful home and bindings matter.

Transformation Workings

Alter Form (Ritual)

Change one defined physical feature or capability for a limited duration.

Shape Matter (Immediate or Ritual)

Reshape a modest amount of nonliving material without changing its fundamental substance.

Warding Workings

Threshold Ward (Ritual)

Protect a boundary against a named category. Strength and duration follow preparation and margin.

Seal (Immediate)

Temporarily hold a door, container, passage, or supernatural breach closed.

Running the Game

Ask what the character wants, what makes the outcome uncertain, and what failure will change. Do not call for a roll when the outcome is obvious. Give essential information needed to continue; roll for quality, cost, danger, time, or additional insight.

Before combat, state the visible stakes, cover, exits, enemy objective, and immediate danger. Opposition should pursue objectives rather than fight until every HP is gone. Check morale and purpose when circumstances change.

For mysteries, provide at least three independent routes to every essential conclusion. Magic may reveal evidence or create access, but it should not replace the players' interpretation of what the evidence means.

Advancement

Characters advance through Advancement Awards rather than character levels. Each standard Advancement Award grants two Skill Ranks. Every third Advancement Award also grants one new Talent. The cycle then repeats.

Advancement Award	Reward
First	2 Skill Ranks
Second	2 Skill Ranks
Third	2 Skill Ranks + 1 Talent
Fourth	2 Skill Ranks
Fifth	2 Skill Ranks
Sixth	2 Skill Ranks + 1 Talent

When a Talent is earned, choose any enabled Talent whose requirements are met. The character explains how it was trained,

awakened, researched, inherited, acquired, or revealed. A Talent cannot be selected twice unless it explicitly says it is repeatable.

Magical access is established in the fiction and is not purchased as a mandatory Talent. A character may learn magical Talents after gaining appropriate access through training, initiation, discovery, supernatural exposure, mentorship, or another campaign event.

At a major story transition, a player may replace one Talent that no longer fits the character, with GM approval. Campaign-granted Talents may be awarded separately when everyone receives the same Origin Talent or a specific story transformation grants the ability.

Advancement is horizontal as well as numerical: contacts, safehouses, magical permissions, workshops, social authority, recovered texts, favors, and changed relationships may matter as much as larger dice. No character must follow a class track or Talent tree.

Quick Reference

Pool: three Ability dice + Skill die + normally one Edge Die.

Protocol Dice: 1–3 blank; 4+ scores face value.

DCs: 8 / 12 / 16 / 20 / 24+.

Margin: 1–3 Narrow; 4–7 Solid; 8–11 Powerful; 12+ Overwhelming.

Turn: 3 AP and one Reaction.

Attack: opposed pools; tie favors defender; damage equals winning margin.

Magic: Practice pool + at most one Edge Die; establish mode and consequence before rolling; overreach expands one axis and guarantees a meaningful consequence.